



PERSONALITY IN THE BRAIN

Scientists have tried to link different personality types to brain structures, but the results have been mixed. We do know that brain damage, particularly to frontal areas, can have an impact on someone's personality, and studies have linked certain traits to differences in brain structure or activity. So far, however, the complexities of both the human brain and our behavior have made the links hard to unravel.



3 Adult personality
As well as environmental factors, such as school or friends, our personality alters due to the fact that our brains do not finish maturing until our early 20s. Our personality goes on to change subtly throughout adulthood.

Crossed arms may indicate defensiveness or insecurity

Fashion choices used to reflect personality

ADULT

Assessing personality

The most common personality assessment, the Big Five test, identifies how a person scores in terms of five traits: openness, conscientiousness, extroversion, agreeableness, and neuroticism. A person is placed along scales for each trait, with one end being the least likely to exhibit this trait, and the other the most.

TRAITS OF LOW SCORERS

Practical; inflexible; prefers routine; conventional, focused

OPENESS

Impulsive; disorganized; dislikes structure; flexible, spontaneous

CONSCIENTIOUSNESS

Quiet; withdrawn; reserved; prefers solitude

EXTROVERSION

Critical; suspicious; uncooperative; insulting; manipulative

AGREEABLENESS

Calm; secure; emotionally stable; relaxed

NEUROTICISM

Openness is the tendency to appreciate new ideas, feelings, and behaviors.

Conscientiousness relates to traits such as following rules and being hardworking.

Extroversion is the tendency toward being sociable, assertive, and expressive.

Agreeableness concerns being cooperative, trustworthy, and kind.

Neuroticism relates to emotional stability and tendency toward negative emotions.

TRAITS OF HIGH SCORERS

Curious; creative; adventurous; unpredictable

Dependable; hardworking; organized; stubborn

Outgoing; articulate; dominant; friendly; talkative

Helpful; empathetic; trusting; caring; polite; amiable; meek

Anxious; easily upset; unhappy; stressed; moody